AI IN GOVERNMENT AND PUBLIC SERVICES - VOLUME 2

The Citizen Services and Digital Front Doors Playbook

One front door for every resident: find it, understand it, complete it - on the web, on the phone, in person, or on paper - with AI that guides, drafts and routes, and people who decide.



Gates C0-C5 | 8 Templates | 20 Golden Rules

The worked example continues from Volume 1: **Northbridge City and County**, a fictional composite government of 480,000 residents, 6,200 staff, and one shared service centre handling 1.9 million resident contacts a year. Every figure attached to Northbridge is illustrative. Adapt the thresholds to your own statute, budget and risk appetite before you use them.

Executive / Service / Accountability lenses on every major section, so a cabinet member, a service owner and an auditor can read the same page and each find their decision.

START HERE

The front door is the government, as far as the resident is concerned

A resident does not experience departments. They experience a search box that finds the wrong page, a form that asks for the same address three times, a phone queue that closes at five, and a letter they cannot understand. Fix the front door and you fix the government's reputation; automate a broken front door and you industrialise the frustration.

How to use this playbook

- **Service owners** read pages 4-16 and run their journeys against the gates on page 29.
- **Executives** read pages 6, 23-25 and the roadmap on page 29, and hold the stop list on page 7.
- **Contact centre and inclusion leads** read pages 17-22 first; the assisted routes are designed there, not bolted on.
- **Auditors and oversight** start at pages 23, 27 and 29-32: measurement, failure drills, gates, templates and rules.

The one test that matters

Every design choice in this volume answers one question: **can this resident complete the task, correctly, in the channel open to them?** Starting a journey is not success. A resident who begins online, fails at identity proofing, phones in, is told to start again, and finally visits in person has used four channels to get one service - and the digital metrics will still record a hit.

Measure **completion**, never traffic. A busier front door is usually a worse one.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Own the completion rate of the top 20 journeys personally; it is the government's most visible number.

SERVICE LENS

A journey is done when the resident has the outcome or a dated next step, not when the form is submitted.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Every channel switch forced on a resident is a defect you can count, publish and fix.

THE SERIES

Where this volume sits

Volume 1 set the strategy: where AI pays, the risk tiers, and the gates. This volume owns everything the resident touches. Later volumes own what happens behind the door.

Vol	Title	Owns
1	Strategy	Mandate, portfolio, risk tiers, gates S0-S5
2	Citizen Services and Digital Front Doors	Find, understand, apply, track, contact - every channel (this volume)
3	Benefits, Licensing and Casework	Eligibility support, evidence, caseworker tools
4	Permitting, Planning and Land Use	Applications, completeness, inspections
5	Tax, Revenue and Compliance	Filing support, queries, payment, debt
6	Procurement and Supplier AI	Buying, contracts, model and supplier governance
7	Emergency Services and Public Safety	Dispatch support, triage, public alerts
8	Data, Records and Interoperability	Registers, records, sharing, retention
9	Workforce, Ethics and Public Trust	Roles, skills, ethics review, public reporting
10	Government Capstone and Assurance	Whole-portfolio assurance and the licence to scale

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DIAGNOSIS

Five doors, no hallway

Northbridge audited its front door before automating any of it. The findings will be familiar. The website held 4,100 pages owned by 31 teams; 900 had not been reviewed in two years. Eleven different phone numbers appeared on the top 50 service pages. The mobile app duplicated the website badly, the chatbot answered from a retired PDF, and the paper forms asked questions the online forms had dropped in 2023.

What the audit counts

- **Doors:** web, mobile, phone, walk-in, post, email, social, partner sites. Each one is a promise; each unwatched one is a lie waiting to be found.
- **Dead ends:** pages with no next step, numbers that ring out, forms that cannot be saved, chat sessions that end with "visit our office".
- **Repeats:** the same fact asked again inside one journey - name, address, date of birth, case number, the story itself.
- **Abandonment points:** the exact step where each journey loses people, by channel, language and device.

> **Northbridge baseline (illustrative):** 38 percent of started online journeys completed; 22 percent of calls were residents asking "did you get it?"; the average resident retold their story 2.7 times per case.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Fund the audit before the assistant. Automating this front door would scale the confusion, not the service.

SERVICE LENS

Pick the top 20 journeys by volume and harm; they carry most contacts and nearly all complaints.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Publish the baseline. A front door you will not measure in public will not improve in private.

DIAGNOSIS

Every channel is a cost, a promise, or both

Channels do not substitute for each other neatly. A resident pushed from web to phone does not vanish from the web statistics; they arrive on the phone angry, with half a form completed somewhere no advisor can see. Channel strategy is therefore journey strategy: one journey, owned end to end, expressed in every channel.

Channel	Best for	Failure mode	Front-door rule
Web / mobile	Standard journeys, tracking, payment	Abandonment at identity and evidence steps	Design mobile-first; save and resume everywhere
AI assistant	Finding, explaining, drafting, routing	Confident wrong answers; dead-end loops	Grounded and cited only; human one step away (p13-14)
Phone	Complexity, distress, negotiation	Queues, retelling, no record for the resident	Advisor sees the whole case (p21); summary sent after every call
Walk-in	Identity, evidence, vulnerability	Travel burden; turned away for missing paper	Never the only route; bookable; evidence scanned once
Post / paper	Legal notice, no-connectivity residents	Slow, silent, error-prone	Tracked on arrival; same case view; plain language (p19)
Partners	Libraries, charities, community hubs	Inconsistent answers	Same content source, trained and supported (p18)

The cheapest contact is the one that never has to happen: a clear letter, a status that updates itself, a renewal that arrives pre-filled. Count avoided contacts as a saving only when the resident's need was genuinely met, never when they simply gave up.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Judge channels as one system with one budget; savings claimed by pushing cost onto residents are not savings.

SERVICE LENS

Keep every channel you cannot run well out of the directory. A listed door that does not open is worse than none.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Track channel switches per journey. Each switch is a design defect with an owner.

THE OPPORTUNITY

AI pays where residents get lost, not where officers decide

The front door's work splits cleanly. Finding, understanding, drafting, checking and routing are language work at scale - exactly where AI earns its keep. Deciding, judging and committing the state are not (page 7).

Use	What it does	Pay-off
Grounded answers	Answers from approved content only, with the source shown	Fewer calls; answers residents can trust and check
Search that understands	Interprets intent and misspellings; ranks the service, not the press release	Residents find the right journey first time
Form co-pilot	Explains questions, pre-fills from the account, checks errors as you go	Higher completion, fewer rejected submissions
Document check	Confirms a document is the right type, legible and in date before submission	Fewer failed applications and repeat visits
Translation and simplification	Drafts plain-language and translated versions for human approval	Language access at a cost government can sustain
Routing and triage	Directs the contact to the right team with a summary attached	No wrong-queue transfers; faster first response
Advisor assist	Summarises the case, drafts replies and letters for advisor approval	Shorter calls, consistent records, less after-call work
Status narration	Turns case events into plain updates: received, checked, waiting, decided	The 'did you get it?' call disappears

Start where the resident is **lost**, not where the organisation is **busy**. The two overlap less than vendors suggest.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Sequence by resident pain and volume: answers, status and forms before anything exotic.

SERVICE LENS

Every use above drafts or guides; a person or a deterministic rule still commits the outcome.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Require the citation. An assistant answer with no source shown is a rumour with good grammar.

THE BOUNDARY

The stop list: what the front door never automates

These lines hold regardless of model quality, vendor claims, or pressure to cut queues. They mirror Volume 1's risk tiers at the point of resident contact.

Never automated	Why	What AI may do instead
Eligibility decisions or refusals	Statutory judgement; a wrong refusal denies a right	Explain criteria; check a draft application for completeness
Any answer presented as a final determination	Residents act on it; appeals start from it	Draft the explanation; an officer issues the determination
Safeguarding or vulnerability judgements	Context and duty of care a model cannot hold	Flag signals to a trained human immediately; never score silently
Enforcement or fraud suspicion at contact	Contact is not investigation; suspicion poisons the interaction	Route factual queries normally; suspicion goes to Volume 5 processes
Identity rejection with no alternative	A failed match is not a fraudulent person	Offer staffed and paper proofing routes of equal standing (p15)
Complaints closed by generated text	A complaint is a citizen speaking to the state	Summarise and route; a named person responds
Legal advice or interpretation of an individual's position	Advice creates reliance and liability	Provide published guidance verbatim, cited, with routes to advisers

> **The disclosure rule:** residents are told, at the point of contact and in plain language, when they are dealing with AI, what it can and cannot do, and how to reach a person. No anthropomorphic names or photos for assistants; no pretending to be staff.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Sign the stop list personally. It will be tested by a queue, a budget round and a vendor, in that order.

SERVICE LENS

Teach the stop list to every advisor; they are the ones who will hold it at 4.55pm on a Friday.

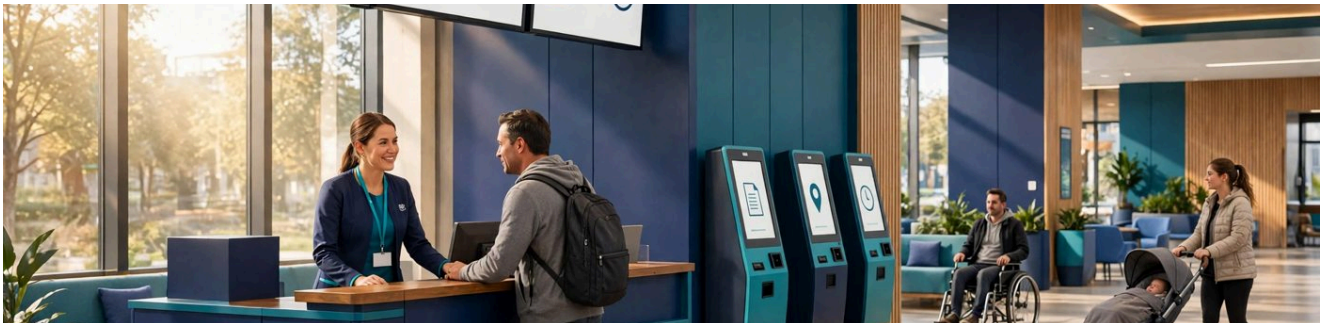
ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Log every attempted breach of the stop list in testing and in production; the log is assurance evidence.

DESIGN

Ten principles, tested at every gate

1. **One front door.** One address, one search, one account, one case view - whatever the department behind it.
2. **Completion over traffic.** The unit of success is a finished task, not a visit, a click or a contained chat.
3. **Show the source.** Every AI answer cites the approved content it used; no citation, no answer.
4. **A human is always one step away.** Visible, reachable, and given the full context when the resident arrives.
5. **Tell people what happens next.** Every submission ends with what happens, by when, and how they will hear.
6. **Ask once.** Data the government already holds is pre-filled or not asked; the story is told once per case.
7. **Plain language is the interface.** Reading age, structure and translation are tested like code (pages 11-12).
8. **Design for the hardest case.** Low literacy, no smartphone, no fixed address, distress, a screen reader, a borrowed phone.
9. **Paper and phone are first-class.** Not legacy, not a penalty route - the same case, the same standard (page 19).
10. **Publish the performance.** Completion, wait, error and equity figures in public, on a fixed cadence (page 24).



Inside the Northbridge service centre: staffed help, self-service and quiet space designed as one journey, not three queues.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Refuse designs that breach a principle and promise to fix it later; later is where principles go to die.

SERVICE LENS

Test each principle with a named journey at every gate; principles without tests are posters.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

A principle breach found in production is an incident, with the same owner and clock as an outage.

ARCHITECTURE

The front-door stack: boring on purpose

Nothing here needs invention. The discipline is in refusing to let each department assemble its own version.

Layer	What it is	Non-negotiable
Content store	One approved source for every answer, page, letter and script	Versioned, owned, dated; the assistant reads only this
Search and intent	Index over the content store plus service directory	Zero-result searches reviewed weekly; synonyms governed
Assistant	Retrieval-grounded model over the content store	Citations mandatory; refusal when no source exists; full logging
Identity and account	One sign-in, tiered proofing, delegated access	Alternatives of equal standing; carers and representatives supported
Forms and workflow	One forms engine wired to case management	Save and resume; pre-fill; accessible by default
Case view	Single timeline across channels for resident and advisor	Every contact, letter, upload and decision in one place
Notification	Status events by text, email, letter or app - resident's choice	Plain language; no silent states; opt-out honoured
Analytics	Journey, equity and quality measurement (p24)	No dark patterns; containment never reported alone

Integration rule: the front door reads and writes through published interfaces to departmental systems. It never becomes a shadow case system of its own, and departments never bypass it with their own chatbots - an unregistered assistant is removed, not debated.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Fund the content store first. It is the least glamorous layer and the one every answer depends on.

SERVICE LENS

Procurement buys components against this stack; point solutions that duplicate a layer need a waiver with an expiry date.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Every layer logs what assurance needs: who or what answered, from which content version, when.

FIND IT

Search is the real homepage

Most residents arrive from a search engine or the site's own search box, mid-task and impatient. Northbridge's logs showed the top 200 resident queries covered 71 percent of searches - and 14 of the top 50 landed on a news story or a PDF rather than the service.

The search discipline

- **Rank the service first.** For a task query ("renew parking permit"), the transactional page outranks news, consultations and committee papers, always.
- **Understand intent, not keywords.** AI-assisted intent matching handles misspellings, colloquial names ("council tax" vs "property tax") and life-event phrasing ("my dad died, what do I do").
- **Zero results is a defect queue.** Every zero-result and dead-end search is logged, reviewed weekly, and answered with content, a synonym, or a redirect - within days, not quarters.
- **One best answer.** For factual queries, show the answer with its source and date above the list of links; residents should not have to open five pages to learn an opening time.
- **Test with real queries.** Search quality is evaluated monthly on a fixed set of real resident queries, scored by humans, in every published language.



At home, on the device they already own: the journey has to work here first, not in the project demo.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Search failure is invisible in most dashboards; demand the zero-result report by name.

SERVICE LENS

Search is a service with an owner and a backlog, not a feature the website came with.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

External search engines are part of the front door: titles and summaries written for residents, not departments.

UNDERSTAND IT

Content design: most front-door failure is content failure

Before Northbridge bought any AI, it rewrote the top 50 service pages. Completion on those journeys rose by a fifth (illustrative) - because the barrier was never the technology; it was paragraphs written by departments, for departments, in the passive voice.

The content standard

- **One page, one task.** Start with the resident's verb ("Apply for", "Report", "Pay"), put eligibility and cost before the form, and the deadline before the explanation.
- **Reading age 11-12 for core content**, shorter sentences, common words, no unexplained acronyms; legal text quoted exactly where the law requires it, and explained beside it.
- **Every page has an owner, a review date and a next review.** Expired content is flagged to its owner, then unpublished if unreviewed - the assistant inherits this hygiene or it inherits the mess.
- **Structured, not decorative.** Headings, steps and eligibility lists written so search, the assistant and screen readers can all use the same source.
- **User-tested before publication.** Five residents completing the task unaided beats fifty internal approvals; test with low-literacy and assistive-technology users in the panel, not as an afterthought.

> **The assistant rule:** the assistant may only answer from content that meets this standard. A question the content cannot answer is a content ticket, not a model problem - and the backlog of those tickets is the truest roadmap for the content team.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Content designers are front-line staff. Fund them before model licences.

SERVICE LENS

A page nobody owns is a future wrong answer. Ownership is checked at gate C1.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

When the assistant and the page disagree, the page is wrong until proven otherwise - one source, fixed once.

UNDERSTAND IT

Language access is a right with a workflow

Northbridge publishes core content in the six languages covering 97 percent of residents who need translation, and provides interpretation on demand beyond them. AI changes the economics of translation; it does not change who is accountable for the words.

Tier	Content	Workflow
Tier 1	Top 50 journeys, all legal notices	Professional translation; AI draft permitted, human translator approves every word
Tier 2	Remaining service content	AI translation with named human reviewer; published with review date
Tier 3	Long-tail and archive	AI translation on request, labelled as machine translation, human version on demand
Live contact	Phone, video, walk-in	Qualified interpreters; the assistant never interprets in a live decision conversation

- **Test in language.** Journeys are tested end to end in each Tier 1 language, including the assistant, error messages and letters - not just the landing page.
- **Names and concepts do not always travel.** Benefit names, deadlines and legal terms get a governed glossary per language; the assistant uses the glossary, not its own invention.
- **Measure equity per language.** Completion and error rates reported by language (page 24); a gap is a defect, not a demographic fact.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Budget translation as operations, not as a project line that ends at launch.

SERVICE LENS

A wrong deadline in translation is a wrong deadline. Tier 1 approval is human, every time.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Residents choose their language once, in the account, and every channel honours it.

ASK IT

The AI assistant: grounded, cited, honest about its limits

The assistant is a guide to published government content, not an oracle and not an officer. Its design brief fits on one line: answer only from the content store, show the source, know when to stop.

Behaviour	Standard	Tested by
Grounding	Retrieval over the approved content store only; no open-web answers on services	Citation present and correct on sampled answers, weekly
Refusal	'I do not have that in the published guidance' plus a route to a human, when no source covers the question	Adversarial and gap-question test sets at every release
No determinations	Explains criteria and process; never states what the resident will get	Red-team scripts attempting to extract decisions
Disclosure	Identified as AI at the start, in plain language, every session	Comprehension testing with resident panel
Conversation memory	Remembers within the session; writes nothing to the case without the resident seeing it	Session-log audit
Tone	Plain, patient, no false familiarity; no name or persona implying a person	Tone review in quality sampling
Escalation	Offers a human on request, on distress signals, on two failed attempts	Handoff drills (page 14)

An assistant that cannot say **"I don't know"** will eventually say something **wrong with confidence** - in the government's name.

Release discipline: every model or prompt change runs the fixed evaluation set - real questions, edge cases, all Tier 1 languages, adversarial prompts - and a named owner signs the results before it ships. The evaluation set grows with every production failure.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Read the refusal rate alongside accuracy; an assistant that never refuses is failing a test you cannot see.

SERVICE LENS

Sample answers weekly, publish the error rate, and name the owner who can switch it off.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

The kill switch is rehearsed, owned, and usable in minutes - including by the duty manager at night.

ASK IT

Handoff: the resident never repeats the story

The measure of an assistant is not how many conversations it contains but how gracefully it leaves them. A handoff that drops the resident into a queue, story-less, converts one failure into two.

The handoff contract

- **Triggers:** resident asks; two failed attempts; distress or vulnerability signals; the question crosses the stop list; the case needs a decision.
- **What travels:** a structured summary - who, what they need, what was tried, what documents exist, language and access needs - written into the case before the human picks up.
- **What the resident gets:** a named queue and a realistic wait, a callback option, and a reference number that works on every channel.
- **Warm where it matters:** safeguarding and distress handoffs are live transfers to trained staff, never a callback promise.
- **The loop closes:** the advisor sees what the assistant said, because the resident will quote it; disagreements are flagged as content defects.

> **Northbridge standard (illustrative):** after handoff, residents repeat on average 0.3 facts, down from 2.7 before the shared case view - the single most praised change in resident feedback.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Judge the assistant and the contact centre as one service; their metrics are reviewed together.

SERVICE LENS

A handoff summary the advisor does not trust will be ignored; co-design it with advisors and audit its use.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Callback means called back - at the stated time, in the stated language, by someone holding the summary.

PROVE IT

Identity and accounts without exclusion

Identity proofing is where digital journeys quietly exclude: no passport, no credit history, a name that changed, an address that is a refuge or a boat. The design question is never "is proofing secure?" but "secure for whom, and who pays for the failures?"

The tiered model

Tier	Used for	Proofing
Browse	Information, calculators, most guidance	None - never gate information behind sign-in
Light	Tracking, notifications, saving forms	Email or phone verification; low friction by design
Standard	Applications, payments, personal records	Document or record-based proofing, plus staffed alternative
High	Sensitive records, representative access	Strong proofing; in-person route staffed and bookable

- **Every digital route has a non-digital twin of equal standing** - staffed proofing at the service centre, or verified paper process - not a lesser service with a longer queue.
- **Delegated access is a first-class feature:** carers, attorneys, parents, support workers and community advocates act with consent that is recorded, scoped and revocable.
- **Failure is data.** Proofing failure rates are published by tier and reviewed for pattern; a spike after a change is a rollback trigger, not a communications problem.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Never let a vendor's default become your exclusion policy; tiering decisions are yours and minuted.

SERVICE LENS

Identity failure must never read as suspicion. The words on the failure screen matter; test them.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Representative access done badly locks out exactly the residents with the most complex cases.

APPLY

Forms that finish

The form is the journey. Most abandonment is not disagreement with the service; it is exhaustion inside the form.

- **Pre-fill what the state already knows** - name, address, household, prior answers - and show it for confirmation rather than asking cold.
- **One thing per screen, question by question**, in the resident's order, not the database's: who, where, what happened, evidence, declaration.
- **Explain as you go.** The co-pilot answers "why do you need this?" beside the question, cites the rule, and warns before an answer will cause rejection - never after submission.
- **Check documents at upload:** right type, legible, complete pages, in date - confirmed on the spot, so failure does not arrive by letter three weeks later.
- **Save, resume, switch.** Start on a phone, finish at a library, hand to an advisor mid-form; the draft and its documents travel with the case.
- **The receipt is a contract:** what was submitted, the reference, what happens next, the date to expect it, and how to add evidence or correct an error.
- **Error recovery is designed, not apologised for:** a rejected submission returns with the specific fix, the saved data intact, and a human route if it fails twice.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Completion by cohort is the headline metric; a form that completes for the confident and fails carers is a failed form.

SERVICE LENS

Every question on a form needs a legal or operational reason on file. 'We have always asked it' ends the discussion the other way.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Test forms on a five-year-old phone, on mobile data, in a Tier 1 language, with a screen reader - before launch, not after the complaints.

ACCESS IN FULL

Accessibility is a launch criterion, not a remediation project

Roughly one resident in five will use a service with a disability, an impairment, or a temporary limitation - a broken arm counts. Accessibility failures at the front door are not usability issues; for a monopoly provider, they are denials of service.

- **Standard:** WCAG 2.2 AA as the floor for every page, form, document and the assistant itself, verified by automated checks and manual assistive-technology testing before launch.
- **Test with the tools residents use:** screen readers, voice control, switch devices, magnification, keyboard-only - in the test panel, on real journeys, with disabled testers paid for their expertise.
- **Documents count.** Letters, PDFs and notices are accessible formats by default; large print, braille, audio and easy-read versions are requestable in the journey, not via a separate phone call.
- **The assistant must degrade gracefully:** full service available without chat, without JavaScript-heavy interaction, and by voice for residents who cannot type.
- **No accessibility debt at the gate.** Gate C2 fails automatically on unresolved critical accessibility defects in a launch journey - no waiver signed under deadline pressure.

> **Report access failures like outages.** A screen-reader user who cannot submit is not a ticket in a backlog; the journey is down for them, and the incident clock runs the same way.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Accessibility sign-off sits with a named owner who can stop a launch, including yours.

SERVICE LENS

Retrofitting costs multiples of designing in; the business case has been settled for a decade.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Publish the accessibility statement with real known issues and dates, not boilerplate assurance.

ACCESS IN FULL

Assisted digital: help is a service, not a fallback

Some residents cannot use digital services, and some will not - because of skills, connectivity, language, confidence, or a life that leaves no slack for learning a portal. Assisted digital is the designed service for them, delivered by people, in places they already go.

Setting	Who helps	What they can do
Service centre	Trained advisors	Complete journeys with the resident; staffed identity proofing; evidence scanning
Libraries	Library staff plus roaming digital champions	Guided completion on library devices; printing and uploading
Community partners	Charities, housing associations, faith and cultural groups	Trusted first help in community languages; referral into the case, not around it
Phone-assisted	Contact centre advisors	Advisor completes the digital journey with the resident live on the call
Home and outreach	Mobile teams for housebound residents	Full journey at home for those who cannot travel

- **Assistance builds or borrows confidence, by the resident's choice:** do it with them, teach while doing, or do it for them - recorded as their preference, respected next time.
- **Partners are funded, trained and given the same content and case tools** - never expected to improvise answers from a leaflet.
- **Assisted demand is measured, not hidden:** rising assisted use of a journey is evidence about the journey's design, reported beside its digital completion rate.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Fund assisted digital as a permanent line. It does not shrink to zero, and pretending otherwise strands residents.

SERVICE LENS

A resident who needs help has not failed the service; note the direction of that sentence in every review.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Partner quality is your quality. Audit it kindly and often.

ACCESS IN FULL

The non-digital promise: paper and phone, first-class

Digital by default becomes coercive the moment the alternatives decay. Northbridge states its promise plainly and publishes performance against it.

The promise

- Every service can be started and completed by phone and on paper, with the same entitlement, the same deadlines counting from receipt, and the same case tracking.
- Paper forms meet the same plain-language and accessibility standards as web pages, and are tested with residents the same way.
- Post is logged on arrival and visible in the case view the same day; a paper applicant can phone and hear exactly what the online applicant sees.
- No channel is closed, shortened or made deliberately worse to hit a digital target. Channel shift is earned by a better digital service, never engineered by a worse human one.
- Letters - still the state's most-read product - are rewritten to the content standard: what this is, what you must do, by when, what happens if you do not, and how to get help, on page one.

The day the paper route becomes a punishment is the day the digital programme loses its **mandate**.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Read complaint themes by channel before approving any channel-change proposal.

SERVICE LENS

Letters are content. The content team owns them, tests them and answers for their failure rate.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Hold the promise in the budget: paper and phone capacity is protected capacity, reviewed annually - not raided quarterly.

BE HEARD

The contact centre, rebuilt around the case

AI absorbs the routine: status, finding, simple explanations, after-call summaries. What remains for advisors is the work that made them essential all along - complexity, distress, negotiation and judgement. Run the centre for that work or lose the people who can do it.



The operations wall: queues, handoffs and journey health in one view, so a bad day is visible before the phones melt down.

- **Advisor assist on every contact:** case summary before the conversation, suggested sources during it, drafted notes and letters after it - approved by the advisor, who remains the author of record.
- **Quality over handle time:** resolution and correctness sampled weekly; handle time watched for harm, not targeted for cuts. A short call that generates two more calls is a long call.
- **Knowledge from the floor:** advisors flag wrong content in one click from the case view; flags are triaged daily - the floor is the content store's best sensor.
- **Surge is planned:** policy changes, deadlines and incidents have rehearsed surge patterns - overtime, callbacks, proactive messages - before the queues form (page 27).

EXECUTIVE LENS

Staff for the work AI leaves behind; it is harder per contact even as volume falls.

SERVICE LENS

Never let the assistant's containment target set the centre's staffing. That equation ends with residents trapped in loops.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Advisor wellbeing is operational capacity: distress work needs rotation, support and sane queues.

BE HEARD

One case view: the resident tells the story once

Every contact - assistant session, call, letter, upload, visit - lands on one timeline that the resident and every advisor can see. This single change does more for trust than any model upgrade.

On the timeline	Why it matters
Every submission and its receipt	Ends 'did you get it?' - the resident can see it arrived
Documents, with check results	Evidence is verified once; re-requests need a reason that shows
Every letter and message sent	Advisors read what the resident read, word for word
Assistant and call summaries	The story is told once; the next human starts informed
Status in plain language	Received, checking, waiting on you, waiting on us, decided - with dates
Decisions and how to challenge them	Appeal routes visible from the decision, not buried in guidance
Access and language preferences	Set once, honoured on every channel, including by partners

- **Resident-visible by default:** internal notes that affect the resident are written knowing they may be read - because one day they will be, under access rights if not on the portal.
- **Corrections are easy and visible:** a wrong fact on the case can be challenged in the view, corrected with an audit trail, and the correction - not just the fact - travels to every team that used it.

EXECUTIVE LENS

The case view is the contract between channels; fund it before adding any new channel.

SERVICE LENS

Data quality on the timeline is a service standard, sampled like call quality.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

If a team keeps a side spreadsheet of 'real' status, the case view has failed - find out why, do not just ban the spreadsheet.

BE HEARD

Proactive and life-event services: news before the question

The best front door is the one the resident does not have to visit. Where entitlement or obligation is already known from held data, the service should move first - carefully, lawfully, and always with consent where the law or decency requires it.

- **Status without asking:** automatic updates at every case event, in the resident's channel and language - the cheapest trust a government can buy.
- **Renewals pre-filled:** licences, permits and passes renewed from held data with a confirm-and-pay step, before expiry, with the paper twin posted in parallel.
- **Life events as one journey:** a birth, a death, a move, a job loss - one notification that coordinates the departments, tells the resident what each will do, and asks each fact once. The bereavement journey is the design benchmark: if it works for the recently bereaved, the mechanics work for anyone.
- **Entitlement prompts:** where held data strongly suggests an unclaimed entitlement, a plain, checkable invitation to apply - never an auto-award, never a nudge that reads as surveillance. The wording is tested for exactly that.
- **Reminders that respect:** deadlines reminded once, helpfully, with the route to help in the same message; reminders stop when the thing is done.

> **The consent line:** proactive contact uses data for the purpose the resident gave it, says so in the message, and stops when told to stop. Trust spent on creepy convenience is not repaid.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Sequence proactivity by kindness and certainty: status first, renewals second, entitlement prompts last and most carefully.

SERVICE LENS

Every proactive message is content: owned, tested, translated, and counted in the channel budget.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Measure harm as well as uptake - a prompt that frightens is a defect even if applications rise.

BE TRUSTED

Trust, transparency and the public register

Residents cannot choose another government, so their trust has to be earned in public, with evidence. Transparency here is operational, not rhetorical.

- **The public AI register** lists every front-door AI use: what it does, the content and data it uses, its owner, its evaluation results, and how to reach a human instead. The assistant itself links to its own entry.
- **Disclosure at the point of use:** plain-language notice when AI is involved, what it can and cannot do, and the human route - tested for comprehension, not buried in terms.
- **Published performance:** completion, accuracy sampling, handoff and equity figures on a fixed quarterly cadence (page 24), including the bad quarters.
- **Feedback that visibly lands:** every assistant answer carries a one-tap accuracy flag; flags are sampled, answered in the quality report, and traced to content fixes.
- **Independent eyes:** the resident panel and the accessibility panel review changes before launch; their objections and the responses are recorded at the gates.

Trust is a **stock**, built by kept promises and spent by every confident error. The register is how residents check the balance.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Publish on the cadence you promised, especially when the numbers are bad; that is the entire point.

SERVICE LENS

If legal advice says a register entry is embarrassing, the entry is the least of the problem - fix the use.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Never market the assistant with a persona. Competence, disclosed, is the brand.

PROVE IT

Measurement: completion, effort and equity - never containment alone

Measure	Definition	Watch for
Task completion rate	Started journeys finished with the outcome or a dated next step, by channel	Gaps by language, disability, age, channel of entry
First-contact resolution	Need met without a second contact within 30 days	False resolution: resident gave up, not succeeded
Resident effort score	Sampled post-journey survey: how hard was that?	Effort rising while completion holds - hidden harm
Answer accuracy	Human-scored sample of assistant answers: right, cited, complete	Confident errors counted separately and weighted worst
Handoff quality	Repeats after handoff; handoff completion; callback kept rate	Summaries written but not read - audit advisor use
Time to outcome	Start to decision or fulfilment, median and 90th percentile	Averages hiding a long tail of stuck cases
Avoided failure contacts	Status and clarification contacts per 100 cases	Counted only alongside resolution, never alone
Equity gaps	Every measure above cut by language, disability, age, deprivation	Any gap widening two quarters running stops scale-up

The containment trap: "the assistant resolved 70 percent without a human" is compatible with residents abandoning in frustration. Containment is reported only beside completion and effort for the same cohort - or not reported at all.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Review equity cuts at the same table as headline numbers, in the same meeting, every time.

SERVICE LENS

A metric that can be improved by making residents go away will be. Pair every volume metric with an outcome metric.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

Baselines from page 4 are republished with results; a programme that moves its baseline moves its credibility.

PROVE IT

Economics: cheaper per answer can still mean dearer per outcome

Illustrative Northbridge unit costs before the programme: web journey 0.40, assistant session 0.90, phone contact 6.80, walk-in 11.50, paper transaction 4.20 (currency units, fully loaded). The trap is optimising the unit you can see.

- **Cost per completed outcome** is the only honest unit: divide the whole front-door budget - content, platform, advisors, assisted digital, paper - by completed tasks. Channel-shifting arithmetic that strands cost elsewhere fails this test.
- **Failure demand is the budget line that matters:** contacts caused by unclear letters, silent cases and rejected forms. Northbridge estimated 31 percent of contacts as failure demand (illustrative); halving it funds the programme without touching a single entitlement.
- **Content is capital.** The content store, glossary and evaluation sets appreciate with use; model licences depreciate. Budget accordingly, and protect content staffing in savings rounds.
- **Assisted digital and paper are in the model, permanently** (pages 18-19). A business case that reaches zero for either line is fiction and will be treated as such at gate C5.
- **Benefits land where they are counted:** fewer repeat contacts, faster time-to-outcome, fewer appeals caused by misunderstanding - each with the baseline from page 4 attached.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Ask for cost per completed outcome by cohort, not cost per contact. The first question ends most bad business cases.

SERVICE LENS

Savings are banked only when the service standard holds for two quarters, equity gaps included.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

The programme's biggest cost is the wrong answer at scale. Price accuracy work as insurance, because it is.

PROVE IT

Workforce: the advisor's job gets harder and better

When the routine leaves, what remains is judgement, empathy and negotiation - on every contact, all day. That is a different workforce proposition, and pretending otherwise burns out exactly the people the service now depends on.

- **Role redesign before deployment:** advisor roles regraded around complexity, with progression into specialist, quality and content roles; nobody learns their future from a launch announcement.
- **Skills that now matter:** verifying AI drafts rather than writing from blank, spotting confident errors, handling distress, digital coaching for assisted digital, and flagging content defects - all trained, all in paid time.
- **Author of record:** advisors approve what advisor assist drafts. Approval is a real act with time allowed for it - a rubber stamp is an accountability gap with a person's name in it.
- **Rotation and recovery:** distress-heavy queues rotate; after-call work is scheduled, not stolen from breaks; wellbeing metrics sit beside performance metrics in the same review.
- **No surveillance creep:** assist tools report on service quality in aggregate; individual monitoring beyond existing, agreed practice is out of scope and stated as such to staff and unions.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Co-design assist tools with advisors; tools imposed on the floor are worked around on the floor.

SERVICE LENS

Headcount plans follow the failure-demand evidence, not the vendor's containment chart.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

The workforce that trusts the tools will tell you when they fail. That reporting channel is safety equipment.

WHEN IT BREAKS

Failure: the assistant will be wrong in public - be ready

Plan for four failures, rehearsed, with named owners and clocks.

Failure	First hour	First week
Confident wrong answer goes viral	Acknowledge publicly; correct the content; assistant paused for that topic; register entry updated	Root-cause published; evaluation set extended; affected residents identified from logs and contacted
Assistant or portal outage	Kill switch / static fallback pages with phone and paper routes promoted; status page live	Post-incident review; surge capacity audit; backlog cleared with proactive updates
Surge: policy change, deadline, incident	Surge pattern on: callbacks, extended hours, proactive messages to affected groups	Demand analysis into content and policy feedback; failure contacts counted honestly
Harmful handoff failure (safeguarding)	Immediate human review of the session; safeguarding lead owns the case	Full review with safeguarding board; drill repeated; stop-list training refreshed

- **Drills:** two live exercises a year - one wrong-answer scenario, one outage at peak - with the press office, the duty manager and the kill switch all actually used.
- **Correction duty:** when an answer was wrong, residents who received it are identifiable from logs and are corrected proactively wherever the answer could have caused action or inaction.
- **No blame, full record:** the incident log is assurance evidence; a culture that hides near-misses guarantees the public version.

EXECUTIVE LENS

Own the first public sentence. Speed and candour in hour one decide the story more than the error does.

SERVICE LENS

The fallback is a service, rehearsed and staffed - not a page that says 'try again later'.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

A drill that cannot embarrass anyone tests nothing.

WHEN IT BREAKS

Build, buy and supplier discipline at the front door

- **Buy components, keep the crown jewels:** the content store, the evaluation sets, the resident data and the case view are government-owned, exportable and operable without the incumbent vendor.
- **Test before contract, exit before signature:** candidate assistants run your evaluation set on your content during procurement; the exit test - content, logs and configurations exported in open formats - is demonstrated, not promised.
- **Contract for the failure modes:** accuracy floors with sampled measurement, incident clocks, model-change notification with re-evaluation rights, and a prohibition on training supplier models on resident conversations.
- **No per-contained-contact pricing.** It pays the vendor when residents fail to reach a human. Pay for availability and measured quality instead.
- **Model changes are releases:** supplier model updates enter through the same evaluation and sign-off as your own releases (page 13); silent upgrades are a contract breach.
- **Accessibility and language performance are contractual**, tested in your Tier 1 languages and assistive technologies, with remedies that bite.

EXECUTIVE LENS

The evaluation set is your negotiating power. Whoever owns it owns the relationship.

SERVICE LENS

Reference-visit services like yours, and ask their advisors - not their sponsors - what the assistant does badly.

ACCOUNTABILITY LENS

If exit cannot be demonstrated in procurement, assume it cannot be done in year three either.

Gates C0-C5: no gate, no launch

C0 Mandate - The front door has one owner, the stop list is signed, and the non-digital promise is funded.

Gate	Evidence required	Automatic fail
C0 Mandate	Named owner; baseline audit (p4); stop list signed; channel promise funded	No single owner; savings target set before baseline exists
C1 Content	Top journeys meet the content standard; Tier 1 translation approved; ownership register complete	Assistant planned on unowned or expired content
C2 Design	Journey tests with resident panel incl. assistive tech; identity tiers and alternatives built	Critical accessibility defects open; proofing with no staffed alternative
C3 Readiness	Evaluation set passed in all Tier 1 languages; handoff drills done; kill switch rehearsed; register entry live	Refusal behaviour untested; callbacks unstaffed; no fallback pages
C4 Proof	Limited launch: completion, accuracy and equity at or above thresholds for 8 weeks	Containment reported without completion; equity gap widening
C5 Scale	Two quarters of published performance; workforce model holding; exit test re-demonstrated	Assisted digital or paper capacity cut to fund scale-up

The 24-month roadmap

1. **Months 0-3:** baseline audit, content rewrites for the top 20 journeys, search fixed, register drafted. Gates C0-C1.
2. **Months 4-8:** content store and case view built; advisor assist piloted; identity tiers launched. Gate C2.
3. **Months 9-12:** assistant limited launch on the top 10 journeys, all Tier 1 languages. Gates C3-C4.
4. **Months 13-18:** status narration and proactive renewals; assisted digital network formalised. Gate C5 for wave one.
5. **Months 19-24:** life-event journeys (birth, bereavement, moving home); scale decision on published evidence.

Volumes 3-5 build on this front door; no back-office automation outruns a front door that cannot explain it.

Templates 1-4: copy, complete, file with the gate evidence

Template 1 - Journey Audit (per journey)

Journey: ___ | Owner: ___ | Annual volume: ___ | Channels offered: ___ | Start-to-completion rate by channel: ___ | Top 3 abandonment points: ___ | Facts asked more than once: ___ | Failure contacts generated per 100 cases: ___ | Baseline date: ___

Template 2 - Content Page Checklist (per page)

Task verb in title: Y/N | Eligibility and cost before the form: Y/N | Reading age checked: ___ | Owner: ___ | Review date: ___ | Tier 1 languages approved: ___ | User-tested (5 residents incl. assistive tech): Y/N | Assistant may cite this page: Y/N

Template 3 - Assistant Release Evaluation

Release / model change: ___ | Evaluation set version: ___ | Accuracy: ___% | Citation correctness: ___% | Refusal correctness: ___% | Stop-list breaches: ___ | Results by Tier 1 language: ___ | Adversarial set passed: Y/N | Signed off by: ___ | Rollback trigger: ___

Template 4 - Handoff Summary (written to the case)

Resident: ___ | Preferred language / access needs: ___ | Need in one line: ___ | Tried so far: ___ | Documents on case: ___ | Agreed next step and date: ___ | Trigger for handoff: ___ | Callback number and time promised: ___

Templates 5-8 and the Volume 2 assurance checklist

Template 5 - Accessibility Launch Check

Journey: ___ | WCAG 2.2 AA automated pass: Y/N | Manual assistive-tech test (tools used): ___ | Disabled testers involved: Y/N | Critical defects open: ___ (must be 0) | Accessible document formats ready: ___ | Signed by: ___

Template 6 - Channel Promise Statement (publish)

Service: ___ | Start and complete by phone: Y/N | On paper: Y/N | Deadlines count from: ___ | Post logged and visible within: ___ | Performance published at: ___ | Promise owner: ___

Template 7 - Wrong-Answer Incident Log

Date/time found: ___ | Question and wrong answer: ___ | Source content version: ___ | Residents who received it (log count): ___ | Correction issued: ___ | Content fixed / assistant paused: ___ | Evaluation set extended: Y/N | Public note published: ___

Template 8 - Quarterly Front-Door Scorecard (publish)

Quarter: ___ | Completion by channel: ___ | First-contact resolution: ___ | Effort score: ___ | Assistant accuracy (sampled): ___ | Handoff repeats: ___ | Equity gaps and actions: ___ | Failure-demand estimate: ___ | Cost per completed outcome: ___

Volume 2 assurance checklist

- Stop list signed, taught and breach-logged; disclosure tested for comprehension.
- Assistant grounded in the owned content store; citations sampled weekly; kill switch rehearsed.
- Every launch journey: accessibility gate passed, Tier 1 languages approved, staffed identity alternative live.
- Handoff contract measured; callbacks kept rate published.
- Non-digital promise funded, stated and reported against.
- Containment never reported without completion and effort for the same cohort.

GOLDEN RULES

20 Golden Rules for the front door

1. Measure completion, never traffic.
2. One front door: one search, one account, one case view.
3. No citation, no answer.
4. An assistant that cannot say "I don't know" will lie with confidence eventually.
5. A human is always one step away - and arrives knowing the story.
6. The resident tells the story once per case.
7. Ask once: pre-fill what the state already holds.
8. Plain language is the interface; test it like code.
9. Translation is approved by humans where rights and deadlines are at stake.
10. Accessibility is a launch criterion; an access failure is an outage.
11. Assisted digital is a service, funded permanently, not a fallback.
12. Paper and phone are first-class; channel shift is earned, never engineered.
13. Identity failure is never treated as suspicion.
14. Every submission ends with what happens next, and by when.
15. Status that updates itself is the cheapest trust in government.
16. Containment reported without completion is a vanity metric.
17. Equity gaps are defects with owners, not demographics.
18. The advisor is the author of record; AI drafts, people commit.
19. Wrong answers are corrected to the residents who received them.
20. Publish the performance, including the bad quarters.

Next: **Volume 3 - Benefits, Licensing and Casework**: eligibility support, evidence, and the caseworker's desk, behind the front door this volume built.

Northbridge City and County is a fictional composite. All figures marked illustrative are examples for adaptation, not benchmarks. Adapt thresholds to your own statute, budget and risk appetite.